

EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

Non-Medical Home Care Agency Template

A customizable handbook framework for caregiver and administrative staff

AGENCY NAME: _____

EFFECTIVE DATE: _____

APPROVED BY: _____

PRIMARY HR / MANAGEMENT CONTACT: _____

IMPORTANT CUSTOMIZATION NOTICE

This template is a starting framework, not a substitute for state-specific employment counsel. Review wage-hour, leave, background screening, mandatory reporting, privacy, meal/rest, final-pay, drug-testing, criminal-history, and other requirements before issuing the handbook to employees.

Before You Issue This Handbook

Complete this checklist before providing the handbook to employees. Remove policies that do not apply and add state, local, payer, or license-specific provisions required for your agency.

- Insert the agency legal name, address, phone, email, and management contacts.
- Confirm whether employment is at-will in your jurisdiction and whether any exceptions apply.
- Insert the agency's pay periods, payroll provider/process, timekeeping rules, overtime-approval process, and pay-day schedule.
- Add state/local leave, sick time, meal/rest, final-pay, scheduling, predictive-scheduling, or reimbursement rules that apply.
- Align background screening, driving, drug/alcohol, health-clearance, TB, vaccination, and training policies with current law and agency requirements.
- Confirm the services caregivers may and may not perform under your agency license and state law.
- Insert mandatory-reporting procedures, emergency contacts, privacy/confidentiality requirements, and complaint channels.
- Have qualified employment counsel review the completed version before implementation.

Do not distribute this template with placeholders still visible. Customize it to the agency that will actually use it.

1. Welcome, Purpose & Handbook Status

Welcome to [AGENCY NAME]. Our mission is to provide dependable, respectful, non-medical support that helps clients remain safe, comfortable, and engaged in their homes and communities.

This handbook explains general workplace expectations, policies, and procedures. It is intended to help employees understand how the agency operates and what is expected of them. It does not create a contract of employment, guarantee hours, guarantee assignments, or alter any rights that cannot lawfully be changed by handbook policy.

The agency may revise this handbook as laws, payer requirements, operational needs, or service models change. When a policy conflicts with applicable law, the law controls.

1.1 Management Contacts

Employees should know who to contact for scheduling, payroll, client-care concerns, safety incidents, complaints, and after-hours escalation.

ADMINISTRATOR / OWNER: _____

SCHEDULER / STAFFING CONTACT: _____

PAYROLL / HR CONTACT: _____

AFTER-HOURS / ON-CALL CONTACT: _____

2. Employment Relationship & Equal Opportunity

[AGENCY NAME] is committed to equal employment opportunity and to a workplace free from unlawful discrimination.

Employment decisions should be based on legitimate business factors such as qualifications, performance, conduct, availability, training, and client-service needs.

If your jurisdiction recognizes at-will employment, insert state-reviewed language here. Do not use a generic at-will statement in a jurisdiction where it is inaccurate or where a written agreement changes the relationship.

2.1 Anti-Harassment and Respectful Workplace

Harassment, bullying, retaliation, intimidation, sexual harassment, and discriminatory conduct are prohibited. Employees should report concerns promptly through any available reporting channel, including a supervisor, administrator, owner, or designated HR contact.

2.2 Reasonable Accommodation

The agency will consider reasonable accommodation requests in accordance with applicable disability, pregnancy, religious-accommodation, and other laws. Employees should contact the designated management/HR representative to request an accommodation.

2.3 Non-Retaliation

Employees who raise a good-faith concern, participate in an investigation, report suspected abuse/neglect, or exercise a protected workplace right should not be retaliated against.

3. Employee Classifications, Assignments & Scheduling

Employees may be classified according to applicable wage-hour rules and the agency's staffing model. Classification labels should be reviewed for legal accuracy and should not be used to avoid overtime or other statutory obligations.

Client assignments depend on client needs, caregiver skills, geography, availability, compatibility, service authorization, and agency policy. The agency does not guarantee a minimum number of hours unless a written agreement expressly provides otherwise.

3.1 Availability and Schedule Changes

- Keep availability current with the scheduling team.
- Do not accept overlapping shifts or assignments you cannot reliably perform.
- Notify the scheduler as early as possible when availability changes.
- Do not privately trade, abandon, shorten, or extend shifts without agency authorization unless emergency circumstances require immediate action.

3.2 Call-Offs and Attendance

Reliable attendance is essential in home care because a missed shift can leave a vulnerable client without expected support. Employees who cannot report to work should follow the agency's call-off procedure and provide as much notice as reasonably possible. No-call/no-show events, repeated lateness, or pattern absenteeism may lead to corrective action, subject to protected-leave and other applicable laws.

3.3 Weather and Emergency Scheduling

The agency will balance employee safety with client continuity needs. Employees should follow emergency communications and never take unreasonable travel risks. Management will determine coverage adjustments and escalation steps.

4. Timekeeping, Payroll & Overtime

Employees must accurately record all time worked using the agency's approved timekeeping method. Off-the-clock work, falsified records, and asking another person to clock in or out are prohibited.

Employees should report timekeeping errors promptly. Supervisors may review records for accuracy but should never direct an employee to under-report hours actually worked.

4.1 Overtime

Nonexempt employees must be paid overtime when required by applicable law. Employees should follow the agency's overtime-approval process, but unauthorized overtime that is actually worked must still be reported and handled according to law. The agency may address unauthorized overtime as a performance issue separately from paying required wages.

4.2 Travel Time, Mileage and Reimbursement

The agency should define which travel is compensable and which business expenses are reimbursable. Employees must use the approved mileage/reimbursement process and should not assume that every commute or trip qualifies. State rules may impose reimbursement requirements beyond federal law.

4.3 Payroll Information

Insert the agency pay frequency, pay day, payroll contact, direct-deposit process, deduction policy, and wage-statement process here.

PAY FREQUENCY / PAY DAY: _____

TIMECARD DEADLINE: _____

PAYROLL CONTACT: _____

5. Client Service Standards & Scope of Role

Caregivers must perform only services they are trained, assigned, and permitted to provide. The service plan and agency policy guide each assignment. When unsure whether a task is permitted, stop and contact the agency before proceeding unless immediate emergency action is necessary to protect life or safety.

- Follow the current service plan and documented client preferences.
- Provide respectful assistance while supporting client independence whenever possible.
- Do not perform skilled nursing, medication administration, medical procedures, or other regulated tasks unless the agency is authorized and the employee is properly qualified and assigned to do so.
- Document services and observations truthfully and promptly.
- Report material changes in condition, falls, injuries, suspected abuse/neglect, medication concerns, hazards, and missed services according to agency procedure.

5.1 Medication Assistance

Non-medical caregivers should provide only the type of medication reminder or assistance permitted by agency policy and applicable law. Employees must not independently change dosages, administer medications beyond their role, or make clinical judgments about medications.

5.2 Transfers and Mobility

Use only approved techniques and equipment for which you have been trained and assessed as competent. Never attempt a transfer that appears unsafe. Contact the office for guidance or additional support.

6. Professional Boundaries, Gifts & Client Property

Employees must maintain professional relationships with clients and families. The client's home is a workplace during assigned service hours, and employees should avoid conduct that could create exploitation, conflicts of interest, dependency, or blurred personal boundaries.

- Do not borrow money from or lend money to clients.
- Do not use client credit cards, bank accounts, passwords, PINs, or financial credentials except through an expressly authorized agency process.
- Do not accept substantial gifts, inheritances, loans, or unusual financial benefits from clients.
- Do not buy, sell, or privately trade goods/services with clients without written agency approval.
- Do not bring unauthorized visitors, children, or pets to a client assignment.
- Do not use client property for personal purposes unless expressly authorized for the assignment.

6.1 Tips and Small Gifts

Insert the agency's actual policy on nominal gifts, food, holiday tokens, and tips. State law, payer rules, client vulnerability, and ethics considerations may affect what is appropriate.

7. Confidentiality, Privacy & Records

Employees may learn sensitive personal, health, financial, scheduling, family, and household information. Such information must be protected and used only for legitimate agency purposes. Employees should follow the agency's privacy policy and any HIPAA or state privacy requirements that apply to the agency's business model and relationships.

- Do not discuss client information in public places or with unauthorized persons.
- Do not post client information, photographs, homes, schedules, or stories on social media.
- Use only agency-approved systems for records, messages, and document transmission.
- Keep paper records secure and return or dispose of them according to agency policy.
- Do not photograph or record clients without explicit authorization and agency approval.

7.1 Documentation Standards

Documentation should be objective, timely, legible, and limited to relevant facts. Do not alter records to hide mistakes. Correct errors using the agency-approved method and report significant documentation errors promptly.

8. Abuse, Neglect, Exploitation & Mandatory Reporting

Employees must immediately report suspected abuse, neglect, exploitation, self-neglect, or unsafe conditions through the agency's designated procedure and to external authorities when required by applicable law. Mandatory-reporting obligations vary by state, profession, age of the client, and circumstances, so the agency must insert state-specific instructions.

8.1 Immediate Danger

If a client or other person appears to be in immediate danger, call 911 or appropriate emergency services first when reasonably necessary, then notify agency management as soon as possible.

8.2 State Reporting Contact

Insert the verified adult protective services, law-enforcement, licensing, and other reporting contacts required for your state.

APS / STATE HOTLINE: _____

AGENCY ESCALATION CONTACT: _____

LICENSING / OVERSIGHT CONTACT, IF APPLICABLE: _____

9. Safety, Infection Prevention & Emergencies

Employees are expected to follow safe-work practices, use required personal protective equipment, and report hazards, injuries, exposures, and incidents promptly.

- Perform hand hygiene and follow infection-prevention procedures appropriate to assigned services.
- Use PPE when required by agency policy, client circumstances, or public-health guidance.
- Do not work while impaired by alcohol, illegal drugs, or medication effects that make assigned duties unsafe.
- Report workplace injuries and exposures immediately using the agency incident process.
- Follow emergency evacuation, severe-weather, utility-outage, and continuity instructions applicable to the client assignment.

9.1 Falls and Medical Emergencies

Do not move a client after a fall or emergency unless trained and it is necessary to prevent immediate danger. Call 911 or follow the agency emergency protocol as appropriate, remain with the client when safe, and notify the office.

10. Driving & Transportation

Employees may transport clients only when transportation is an authorized agency service and the employee, vehicle, insurance, driving record, client authorization, and assignment satisfy the agency's current transportation policy.

- Obey traffic laws and seat-belt requirements.
- Never text or use a handheld device while driving.
- Do not transport unauthorized passengers.
- Report accidents, citations, license restrictions, or insurance changes promptly.
- Follow agency procedures for mobility equipment and accessible transportation.

11. Communication, Phones, Social Media & Technology

Professional communication is required with clients, families, coworkers, referral partners, and management. Personal-device use should not interfere with client supervision or service delivery.

- Use agency-approved communication channels for client information.
- Do not post client images, names, stories, addresses, or schedules online.
- Do not conduct private side-business solicitation with agency clients.

- Do not record calls or conversations unless permitted by law and agency policy.
- Report lost devices containing agency information immediately.

12. Dress, Hygiene & Identification

Employees should arrive clean, appropriately dressed, and ready to perform assigned duties safely. Insert the agency's uniform, footwear, identification-badge, fragrance, jewelry, nail, and infection-control expectations here. Reasonable accommodation requests should be handled according to law.

UNIFORM / DRESS STANDARD: _____

IDENTIFICATION BADGE REQUIREMENT: _____

13. Performance, Coaching & Corrective Action

The agency may use coaching, retraining, warnings, reassignment, suspension, or separation when performance or conduct does not meet expectations. The agency may choose the response appropriate to the circumstances and applicable law; progressive discipline is not guaranteed unless the agency expressly adopts it.

13.1 Examples of Serious Conduct Concerns

- Abuse, neglect, exploitation, theft, fraud, or intentional falsification of records.
- Working while impaired or possessing prohibited substances during service.
- Abandoning a client or leaving an assignment without appropriate relief or agency direction.
- Performing prohibited medical or clinical tasks outside the employee's role.
- Breach of confidentiality or unauthorized posting of client information.
- Violence, threats, harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or serious insubordination.
- Unsafe driving or transporting a client without required authorization.

14. Complaints, Open-Door Reporting & Investigations

Employees are encouraged to raise workplace concerns promptly. Reports may involve scheduling, payroll, harassment, safety, client care, supervision, retaliation, ethics, or suspected policy violations. The agency should identify at least two reporting channels so an employee is not forced to report only to the person involved in the concern.

PRIMARY COMPLAINT CONTACT: _____

ALTERNATE COMPLAINT CONTACT: _____

14.1 Cooperation and Confidentiality

Employees are expected to cooperate honestly in reasonable workplace investigations. Information will be shared only as appropriate for investigation, safety, legal compliance, and business needs; absolute confidentiality cannot be guaranteed.

15. Leave, Time Off & Benefits

Insert only the leave and benefit policies actually offered or required. Federal, state, and local rules may govern sick leave, family/medical leave, pregnancy-related leave, military leave, jury duty, voting leave, domestic-violence leave, bereavement, PTO payout, and other protected absences.

PTO / VACATION POLICY: _____

SICK LEAVE POLICY: _____

HOLIDAY POLICY: _____

BENEFITS OFFERED: _____

16. Separation from Employment

Employees separating from the agency must return agency property, records, keys, badges, equipment, and confidential information. Final-pay timing, PTO payout, deductions, benefit continuation, and personnel-file rights vary by jurisdiction and must follow applicable law.

16.1 Client Transition at Separation

Former employees must not retain client records, schedules, access credentials, or confidential agency information. Any post-employment restriction or non-solicitation provision should be separately reviewed for enforceability under applicable law and should not be assumed valid simply because it appears in a template.

17. State / Local Policy Addendum

Use this section to insert jurisdiction-specific requirements identified during legal/compliance review. Examples may include wage notices, sick leave, meal/rest rules, reimbursement, predictive scheduling, final pay, criminal-history limits, privacy notices, mandatory reporting, training hours, health-clearance requirements, and required employee notices.

Requirement / Topic	Agency Policy / Rule	Source / Effective Date
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18. Employee Acknowledgment

I acknowledge that I received the [AGENCY NAME] Employee Handbook and understand that I am responsible for reading and following the policies that apply to me. I understand that this handbook is a general policy guide and is not a promise of guaranteed hours, assignments, benefits, or continued employment. I understand that policies may be changed as permitted by law and that I should ask management if I have questions.

EMPLOYEE PRINTED NAME: _____

EMPLOYEE SIGNATURE: _____

DATE: _____

AGENCY REPRESENTATIVE / WITNESS: _____

Appendix A — Final Customization Checklist

- All placeholders replaced with actual agency information.
- State/local employment-law review completed.
- Pay, overtime, timekeeping, and reimbursement policies match actual practice.
- Leave and benefits sections match actual offerings and legal requirements.
- Caregiver scope-of-role language matches license and state rules.
- Mandatory-reporting contacts and procedures verified.
- Transportation and driving requirements verified with insurer.
- Privacy/confidentiality language matches agency systems and contracts.
- Complaint/reporting contacts current.
- Acknowledgment page ready for employee signature.